WAXING ELOQUENT
Raj Thackeray has donned the Hindutva mantle he says the Sena has abandoned

the assembly and 15 in the BMC to stay relevant," says an MNS leader. "We had no choice but to toe the Hindutva line; it has the maximum traction."

Even the choosing of the Hanuman Chalisa seems to be a tactical ploy. "I chose Hanuman Chalisa over Maruti Stotra (Marathi version of the chalisa) so that people from across the country could recite it," Raj told a newschannel. Experts see in it an effort to woo north Indians, who have a 20 per cent vote share in Mumbai. "Raj is looking to shed his anti-north Indian image through the Chalisa," says Hemant Desai, a political analyst. A visit to Ayodhya on June 5 is the next step in this direction. The strategy seems to have worked. Gaurav Singh, a Thane resident, says north Indians appreciate the focus on Hindutva. "We considered Shiv Sena closer to us than MNS. As Uddhav is no longer interested in Hindutva and Raj has extended an olive branch, north Indians will prefer him over Uddhav," says Singh, a third-generation north Indian from Mumbai.

There is speculation that MNS will join hands with the BJP before the local body polls, including for the BMC, 14 other municipal corporations, zilla parishads and others, are held in September-October. Surely, they need to unite to defeat the MVA. But there is no official word. Leader of Opposition Devendra Fadnavis says it is mere rumour. "There is no question of forging an alliance with MNS. We'll return to power on our own," he said. Adds a BJP core committee member for Mumbai: "We are in a better position to win Mumbai. If we announce an alliance with MNS, it will upset BJP ticket hopefuls as their chances weaken." According to an MNS source, Raj has accepted the BJP's proposal to field 25 candidates against sitting Shiv Sena corporators for the BMC polls. The fight between the Thackeray cousins may affect the BJP's future more than other factors. ■

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FOR YOURSELF AND OTHERS

A barrage of markings conveying significant information remain an important presence on the surface of roads. Motor vehicles departments across the world meticulously chart these basics of roads for guiding the public and ensuring their safety. Each of these markings serve distinct functions.

Broken White Line

The broken white line imparts the permission to change lanes, overtake and take U-turns. However, it must be taken into consideration that before executing any of these manoeuvres, one must check the surroundings, oncoming traffic and the traffic behind.

Continuous White Line

On this road, overtaking other vehicles or taking U-turns is allowed. This is mostly the case when the road is narrow and because traffic is generally heavy. At the same time, these are seen on hilly roads where there are frequent blind corners. One must never attempt an overtake around a corner.

Continuous Yellow Line

A continuous yellow line issues instructions to stay within the yellow line. On the upside, it allows one to overtake as long as one stays within the yellow line. These roads are usually seen in areas with low visibility to establish the need to stay on one's side of the road.

The Double Continuous Yellow Line

Over the course of time, the NHAI or state and municipal corporations gather data on roads. Some sections of the road showcase themselves as accident-prone zones. Hence this sort of marking is laid on. A double continuous yellow line implies that crossing the line is strictly not permitted for either side. So that means no overtaking, no U-turns or no lane changes.



Spare a Thought for Pedestrians

Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways, Nitin Gadkari recently said in Rajya Sabha that a total of 23,483 pedestrian deaths due to road accidents were recorded in 2020. Speaking about the issue of road safety, Gadkari further added that in order to prevent road accidents and save lives, the Motor Vehicle Act was amended to focus on road safety. This will include stringent implementation of laws and heavy fines. Both the pedestrian behind the wheels & the pedestrian should act with caution. The pedestrians must make use of foot over bridges and climbing over road dividers. So the key is to be a better guy while behind the wheel and even as a pedestrian.